

French Polynesia- Itinerary, Restaurant Recommendations, Souvenir Buying

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Your French Polynesia Itinerary

Day 1: Fri, Feb 28 – Arrival in Tahiti

- Catch your flight from SFO at 1:20pm
- Arrive in Tahiti at 8:00pm
- The driver will pick you from the airport (already confirmed) and drop you to the hotel
- Check in to your hotel, grab a bite and get some rest!

Day 2: Sat, Mar 1- Explore Tahiti, Transfer to Moorea

- Have breakfast at one of the cafes. Consult the Café and Restaurant Guide
- Embark on some sightseeing in Papeete
 - Visit the vibrant [Papeete Market](#).
 - Then head to the [Notre Dame Cathedral](#)
 - Take a stroll around the [Papeete Town Hall](#), inspired by the old palace of Queen Pomare.
- Have lunch. Consult the Café and Restaurant Guide.
- Then head to the [ferry terminal](#) to catch your 2:45 pm ferry
- Arrive at Moorea and pick up your self- drive car
- Check in to your hotel, relax on the beach or by the pool, enjoying the stunning views of the lagoon.
- For dinner options, consult the Café and Restaurant Guide; talk to your driver if you need transport.

Day 3: Sun, Mar 2 - Explore Moorea

- Spend the morning snorkeling around the property
- After lunch, drive around and explore the island
 - [Toatea Lookout](#) – A beautiful spot where you can admire the Sofitel Hotel with its overwater bungalows, the turquoise lagoon, the reef protecting the island, and Tahiti in the distance.
 - [Cook's Bay](#) – Discover lush vegetation and a pineapple plantation on the mountainside.
 - [Tahiamanu Public Beach](#) – Perfect for taking photos, located between the two bays.
 - [Tropical Garden Viewpoint](#) – Offers a stunning view of the second bay, called "Opunohu," which is more wild and untouched. You can also have fresh juices here.
 - [Belvedere Lookout](#) – Located in the heart of the valley at 400 meters altitude, this viewpoint offers an incredible view of both bays and Mount Rotui. A must-see
 - Return back to your resort
- For lunch and dinner options, consult the Café and Restaurant Guide.

Day 4: Mon, Mar 3- Transfer to Bora Bora

- After breakfast, check out and drive to the airport, drop off your car
- Catch your flight at 10:50 am to Bora Bora
- On arrival at 12:20pm, transfer to Westin Bora Bora and check into your overwater bungalow. This transfer is arranged from your resort.
- Spend the day relaxing, enjoying the stunning views and indulging in the luxurious amenities of your resort

Day 5: Tues, Mar 4- Explore the resort

- Spend the day exploring the resort and its many amenities.

Day 6: Wed, Mar 5- Half Day Snorkeling Trip

- Spend a leisurely morning taking the snorkeling tour offered by Westin
- Spend the evening relaxing on the property

Day 7: Thurs, Mar 6- Day of relaxation; sunset cruise and stargazing

- Spend a day at leisure, in the resort
- In the evening, enjoy a romantic sunset cruise with breathtaking views of the island and participate in stargazing.
- Hotel pickup and drop off is included
- Spend the night in Bora Bora

Day 8: Fri, Mar 7- Explore Bora Bora

- Take a private minivan ride around Bora Bora. Discover the interiors of the island and its breathtaking landscapes. Discover the terrestrial flora and fauna. Soak up the local culture, punctuated by the sounds of the ukulele, and the joy of the life of the locals. Enjoy and authentic Polynesian experience with sunset options
- You will be visiting Vaitepe, Faanui, Outuoreho viewpoint, Matira beach
- Inclusions:

- Private transport in an AC vehicle that is wifi enabled
- Tropical fruits and refreshments (can be catered to veg)Spend the rest of your day relaxing in the resort
- Spend the rest of the day relaxing in the resort

Day 9: Sat, Mar 8- Fly back home via Tahiti

- After a leisurely morning, check out
- Travel to the airport (this transfer is arranged by your hotel)
- Fly to Tahiti at 4:10pm
- Catch your flight from Tahiti at 8:40pm to SFO

Cafes and Restaurant Guide

In Tahiti

[Le Retro](#)

Located in the Vaima Shopping Centre, it is known for its French cuisine and its lively atmosphere. Some of the must try dishes are its crab cake, shrimp curry, tomato and mozzarella salad,

- Cuisine: French
- Timings: 07:00 am – 11:00 pm

[Yummy](#)

They offer a wide variety of sweet and savory crepes, all made fresh to order. The menu features classic French crepes, as well as some unique Tahitian-inspired creations. The creperie is located in a charming spot with a relaxed atmosphere, making it the perfect place to enjoy a delicious meal

- Cuisine: Creperie
- Timings: 06:00 am – 04:00 pm; closed on Sunday

[Le Petite Maison](#)

It is a French bistro-style restaurant offering traditional French cuisine in a charming setting.

- Cuisine: French
- Timings: 06:30 am – 10:00 pm; 7am- 2pm on Saturday; closed on Sunday

[Café Maeva Marche de Papeete](#)

It is a must-visit spot located on the first floor of the Papeete Market. The café offers a variety of options including breakfast, lunch, and dinner. It has indoor and outdoor seating, and is known for its relaxed atmosphere, friendly service, and delicious food. The menu features classic French dishes and local favorites, as well as a variety of drinks. Café Maeva is the perfect place to enjoy a meal or a drink while taking in the sights and sounds of the Papeete Market.

- Cuisine: French/Tahitian
- Timings: 07:30 am – 3:30 pm; they however might not have breakfast service on Saturday so don't count on it but do try to swing by on your visit to the market

In Moorea

[Moz Café](#)

It is a small restaurant on the second floor of a small building with a local vibe. It has great views of the ocean and free wifi. It is open for breakfast, lunch, and dinner, and serves coffee, beer, wine, and dessert.

- Cuisine: Café
- Timings: 08:00 am – 08:30 pm; open only till 2pm on Monday; closed on Sunday

[Snack Mahana](#)

Located just down the road from the InterContinental Resort this place is always packed with locals and tourists alike! Offering fresh fish served in a variety of styles as well as steak, chicken and other “roulotte” type dishes. This little snack restaurant is a gem and is perfect for lunch given its gorgeous outdoor lagoon side setting – but we recommend you book a table or you may miss out!

- Cuisine: Local roulotte
- Timings: 11:00 am – 2:00 pm; closed on Sunday and Monday

[Roulette le spot 64 Moorea \(5 min walk from Sofitel\)](#)

A food truck option for a quick takeaway known for their burritos and poke bowls, sandwiches

- Cuisine: Takeout
- Timings: 10:30 am – 04:00 pm; closed on Sunday

[Carameline](#)

It is a beloved snack and pastry shop known for its delicious homemade pastries, from traditional viennoiseries to unique tropical flavors. They also offer a variety of savory options, including burgers, salads, and local dishes featuring fresh fish and meats. Carameline is a great spot for breakfast, lunch, or a sweet treat, with friendly service and a relaxed atmosphere.

- Cuisine: Café- bagels, coffee, tarts
- Timings: 06:30 am – 05:00 pm

[Rudy's](#)

It is a popular French restaurant in Moorea known for its delicious food and island flavors. It has been a local favorite for over 40 years, and is now run by the son of the original owner. The menu features a variety of tasty meats and fresh seafood, and the restaurant is known for its friendly service and relaxed atmosphere. Sofitel offers a free shuttle

- Cuisine: French
- Restaurant Timings: 5:30 pm – 9:00pm; closed on Wednesday

[Moorea Beach Café](#)

A popular waterfront restaurant in Moorea, known for its stunning lagoon views, especially at sunset. The cafe offers a diverse menu with international and local cuisine, including fresh seafood, sushi, and wood-fired pizzas. It's a great spot for a casual lunch, a romantic dinner, or cocktails by the water. They also have a lively bar and often feature live music.

Sofitel offers a free shuttle

- Cuisine: Polynesian
- Restaurant Timings: 08:00 am – 09:30 p

[Te Honu Iti](#)

Offering a varied menu, this little restaurant offers free transfers from most hotels. Taking advantage of its lagoon-side location, it attracts the local marine life with sting rays often cruising the lagoon waters beneath.

- Cuisine: Multi-cuisine
- Restaurant Timings: 11:00 am – 2:30 pm; 6:00pm- 09:30 pm

In Bora Bora

[Le Gecko](#)

Located in Oa Oa Lodge, it is a restaurant that offers a culinary experience that captures the essence of Bora Bora's vibrant culture and stunning scenery. Located amidst the lush greenery and azure waters of this tropical paradise, Le Gecko offers a menu that celebrates local flavors with a contemporary twist.

The restaurant's ambiance is as inviting as its menu, with a decor that reflects traditional Polynesian motifs creating a warm and welcoming environment

- Cuisine: Polynesian
- Restaurant Timings: 06:30 am – 09:30 am; 11:00 am – 01:30pm; 05:30 pm- 08:30 pm

[Bora Bora Yacht Club, Vaitape](#)

The restaurant is located in the Yacht Club. It is open for lunch and dinner and offers a chilled-out atmosphere with an open air deck setting with fabulous views across the lagoon. Some of the recommended dishes are the Coconut Ceviche, Tahitian Marinated Raw Tuna Salad with Coconut Milk

- Cuisine: Local
- Restaurant Timings: 10:30 am – 11:00 pm

[The St. James](#)

This restaurant overlooks the lagoon and provides a picturesque setting. It is a mainly seafood menu, cooked French style. There is also a lagoon-side bar from which you can enjoy a pre-dinner drink. A great place to spot the rays! Some of the recommended dishes are the baked brie, fish and chips, Le Mahi Mahi, Just caught lobster

Make a reservation- saintjamesborabora.com

- Cuisine: Local with fresh seafood specialties.
- Restaurant Timings: 6:30 am- 11:00 pm. Closed on Sunday

[Iaorana Gelato Homemade Italian Ice Cream](#)

A popular icecream shop that serves homemade Italian Gelato. The shop has a wide variety of flavours, including both classic and tropical options. The gelato is made with fresh ingredients and is said to be very delicious.

- Cuisine: Gelato
- Restaurant Timings: 08:30 am – 04: 30 pm; 5:30 pm- 09:30 pm

[Bora Healthy](#)

It serves a variety of American and local dishes, including burgers, sandwiches, salads, and seafood, wraps and paninis

- Cuisine: Cafe
- Restaurant Timings: 10:00 am – 02:00 pm; 06:00 pm – 09:00 pm; closed on saturday

Famous Polynesian Dishes

- Poisson Cru au lait de coco- Raw fish marinated in coconut milk and lime. It's similar to ceviche but with a creamy twist from the coconut milk
- Poulet fafa- chicken cooked with taro leaves and coconut milk. It's often prepared in a traditional underground oven called an ahima'a, giving it a smoky and earthy flavor.
- Po'e- A sweet and starchy pudding made from taro, banana, or pumpkin, Po'e is a popular dessert. It's cooked in an ahima'a and served with coconut cream.
- Fafaru- For the adventurous palate, Fafaru is a unique dish of fish marinated in fermented seawater with crushed shrimp. It has a strong aroma and flavor that's an acquired taste, but locals and some visitors swear by it.
- Pahua Taïoro- an exquisite Tahitian dish that can be based on clams (*pahua*) soaked in fresh water for a few hours before being combined with *taïoro*, a condiment made by fermenting almonds, grated coconut, seawater, and shrimps.
- Firi Firi- These Tahitian doughnuts are a popular breakfast treat. They're made with flour, coconut milk, and sugar, then deep-fried until golden brown. They're often served with fruit or jam.
- Chevrettes- These freshwater prawns are a local delicacy. They're often grilled or cooked in a flavorful sauce. It is a dish specific for the Tahitian cuisine. This highly nutritious appetizer consists of peeled and deveined shrimps, oil, sliced Tahitian vanilla beans, coconut milk, rum, cream, salt, and black pepper.
- Breadfruit- This versatile fruit is a staple in Polynesian cuisine. It can be roasted, boiled, or fried and has a starchy texture and mild flavor.
- Coconut Crab- This large land crab is a prized ingredient in some dishes. It's known for its rich and flavorful meat.
- Taro- This root vegetable is a staple in Polynesian cuisine. It can be cooked in various ways, including boiled, mashed, or baked.

What to buy in French Polynesia?

- **Tahitian Black Pearls:** These gems are renowned worldwide for their luster and unique colors. Find them in Papeete's pearl markets or at pearl farms in Moorea.
- **Monoï Oil:** This fragrant oil, made from coconut and tiare flowers, is a Polynesian beauty secret. It's available in various forms, from lotions to soaps, and can be found in most shops.
- **Vanilla:** Tahitian vanilla is prized for its intense aroma. Purchase beans, powder, or extract from markets or plantations, especially on Taha'a (accessible from Moorea).
- **Pareos:** These colorful, versatile cloths are a symbol of Polynesia. You can find them in countless designs and can wear them as sarongs, dresses, or use them as décor.
- **Wood Carvings:** Skilled artisans create intricate sculptures, often depicting Tiki figures or marine life. Look for them in markets or art galleries.
- **Tifaifai:** These colorful patchwork quilts are a unique Polynesian craft.
- **Shell Jewelry:** Beautiful necklaces, bracelets, and earrings made from shells are readily available.
- **Local Food Products:** Consider buying local honey, jams, or noni juice.

Where to buy:

Papeete Market: This vibrant market is a must-visit for souvenirs, local crafts, and fresh produce.

Moorea's Artisanal Village: This village showcases traditional crafts like wood carving, jewelry making, and weaving. You can often watch artisans at work.

Vaipete: This area is known for its pearl farms, where you can learn about pearl cultivation and purchase high-quality pearls.

Mobile Connectivity while in French Polynesia

- There are 2 main providers- Vini and Vodafone
- **My recommendation is for the Vini sim as they have the best 4G/5G mobile data network across all the islands.**
- The best place to buy a prepaid sim card is in the airport on arrival. At the Relay store, you will find the Vini sim cards and there is also a Vodafone store should you prefer that.
- The Relay convenience store is on your right hand side in the food court opposite the car rental companies.
- You can also purchase an e-sim like Holafly or Airalo if you want international roaming but without a physical sim
- Be aware that the Airport in Papeete does not offer free WiFi.

Important Numbers in French Polynesia

Here are few numbers you may need while in French Polynesia

- 15- Ambulance
- 17- Police

Recommended things to buy/carry

- Travel Insurance
- Summer caps
- Sunscreen
- Travel adaptors
- Doctors prescriptions/travel prescriptions for medicines (except over the counter meds)
- Comfortable shoes
- Swim wear
- Portable chargers
- Forex (cash and cards)-

Recommended Apps

- Google Translate
- Google Maps

Common Phrases in French Polynesia

French Polynesian Words	Meaning in English
La ora na	Hello
Nana	Goodbye
Maururu	Thank you
E!	Yes
Aita	No

Regarding Foreign Currency

- The French Pacific Franc (xpf) is the currency of French Polynesia
- 1 xpf = 0.0088 USD
- USD is also widely accepted
- While most big establishments like restaurants and shops accept cards, You will need cash for your small shops/street shopping